Diseases (SHPD) attributed psychiatric problems in militancy-wrecked areas to fear, stress, coping with the murders of family and friends and seeing mutilated bodies after terrorist attacks. In 2009, SHPD recorded about 97,000 psychiatric cases from FATA, Swat, Tank, Hangu, Darra Adam Khel and other areas hit by violence. In 2010, the number was about 22,000, including women and children who suffered from severe PTSD.

According to a report released by the global health agency, 'most of the IDP suffered from various forms of mental distress'. Mentally disabled children, who lack specialised care that could prevent problems from becoming major health concerns, were most vulnerable. Nevertheless, women and children in general were a concern, the report found.

According to WHO, about 4 per cent of the population suffer from severe psychiatric disorders, but 'a much larger portion of the population suffers from transient mental health problems linked to the stress of living under conditions of conflict and violence'.

The WHO had recommended management of urgent psychiatric conditions at the primary health care level, including referral to psychiatric hospitals and continued treatment of chronic psychiatric patients. Victims of severe mental traumas due to the conflict and subsequent displacement should receive psychological support, it suggested.

Disabled persons and victims of violence remained disadvantaged during distribution of humanitarian assistance, especially food, and were more susceptible to mental health problems, Professor Mohammad Shafiq, a senior psychiatrist in Mardan, told Central Asia Online.

As stated by Gul Jamal, a farmer from Swat at Shafiq's clinic, 'I had several orchards destroyed by militants. During the army operation, we stayed in Mardan district as IDPs, where we queued for food and other essential items.' He said that the Taliban turned him from an aid contributor into an aid recipient. As Shafiq stated, 'The farmer needed psychological support to restore his confidence.'

The provincial health department in its post-conflict rapid assessment in Swat revealed that 27 of the valley's 228 health facilities were destroyed, while 54 suffered partial damage that would cost an estimated Rs 1.2 billion ($14 million) to fix.

As stated in the assessment, 'This has put the population in a precarious situation because it needed urgent treatment . . . particularly for mental ailments.'